PulseHR Internal Research Brief

Topic: Leave request approval friction
Prepared for: Design + PM, Q2 planning

Method: 14-question survey sent to all people-managers (212 respondents, 61% response rate), plus 8 follow-up interviews with a mix of managers and employees.

Key findings

68% of managers said they have forgotten about a pending leave request at least once, usually because it arrived as one more email in a crowded inbox with no reminder.

Average time from request submitted to request approved was 4.2 days across the sample, with wide variance: 71% were resolved within 2 days, but a long tail of 12% took over a week.

Employees consistently described the current status view as unclear - the portal shows 'Pending' with no indication of who it is waiting on or how long that is likely to take.

A recurring request from managers: let me approve from wherever I already look every day (email or Slack), not a separate portal I have to remember to open.

Recommendation going into design

Treat the approval as an inbox-style queue, not a buried settings page, and surface status (who it is with, how long they have had it) back to the employee without them needing to ask.